

Short Introduction to Philosophy - Subject: Argument against Religion

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Section I: Introduction

In this paper, I aim to argue against one of the claims that support “Betting on God”. In this first section, I will give insight into the author’s argument as to why it is rational to believe in God. In the second section, I will argue against the claim made in BG1 of the Argument for Betting on God. In the third section, I will address and counter possible objections to my argument. This paper argues that one shouldn’t always choose the option with the greatest expected utility, as many other factors come into play when making a decision.

The author’s argument for “Betting on God” consists of two premises and a conclusion:

(BG1) One should always choose the option with the greatest expected utility

(BG2) Believing in God has a greater expected utility than not believing in God

(BG3) So you should believe in God

(Learning from Arguments, Korman 22)

The first premise argues that the option with the greatest expected utility is the most logical choice, as “expected utility calculations do such a good job of reflecting the rational thing to do” (36). To calculate expected utility, multiply the attributed value by the likelihood associated with that eventuality, and sum the products across the outcomes. When one option has a higher expected utility than another, it indicates a greater potential for benefits relative to the risks. This calculation helps assess whether an action will likely generate a desired outcome. The author uses these facts to reinforce the first premise, showing that expected utility calculations provide a good framework for weighing eventualities against each other. Through this reasoning, he advocates that the choice with the highest expected utility should always be picked.

The second premise asserts that believing in God is more advantageous than not believing due to the greater expected utility associated with belief. The author demonstrates with this table:

	God exists 1%	God doesn’t exist 99%	Expected Utility
Believe in God	∞	2	∞
Don’t believe in God	1	3	2.98

(Learning from Arguments, Korman 40)

The values of 1, 2, and 3 are distributed based on the ranking of how favorable that outcome is, with 1 being the value of the least favorable outcome. The expected utility of believing in God is

derived from the formula $(\infty * 0.01) + (2 * 0.99)$, while the expected utility of disbelief in God is derived from the formula $(1 * 0.01) + (3 * 0.99)$. Considering the reality where God exists, the expected utility of belief would be a “value of infinity” (39), as the reward is the eternal afterlife. Due to the nature of heaven, the value is incomparable to any of the other scenarios as the advantage is “infinitely greater than what you get in any of the other eventualities” (39). The author emphasizes that the minimal and finite risks of believing in God in a reality where he doesn't exist are far overshadowed by the appealing possibility of infinite value after you die.

Section II: Objection

The author's premise in BG1, that one should always choose the option with the greatest expected utility, is flawed. In this section, I will examine a case where choosing the option with the higher expected utility is not always the best choice, countering the author's claim.

Consider the case of a terminally ill patient faced with two choices. The first choice is to undergo a very uncomfortable, aggressive treatment aimed to cure the disease with a 10% success rate. The second choice would be palliative care, which would relieve the patient of their symptoms before they die but wouldn't offer a chance of recovery. One can represent this scenario with an expected utility table:

	Aggressive Treatment Works (10%)	Aggressive Treatment Doesn't Work (90%)	Expected Utility
Aggressive Treatment	100	1	10.9
Palliative Care	5	10	10.5

To preface, I've attributed a much higher value to the eventuality where the aggressive treatment works, as curing the disease is the most desired outcome. The value of 10 is the second highest eventuality, representing the ease of palliative care and 5 is attributed to the eventuality where aggressive treatment would have worked. 1 is the value of the least desirable outcome, as the painful suffering of the aggressive treatment was experienced for no reason. The expected utility of aggressive treatment is calculated by $(100 \times 0.1) + (1 \times 0.9)$, resulting in a value of 10.9. In contrast, the expected utility of palliative care is calculated by $(5 \times 0.1) + (10 \times 0.9)$, resulting in a value of 10.5.

Although the expected utility of aggressive treatment is higher than that of palliative care, practical issues prevent one from simply choosing the option with the greater expected utility. In this scenario, one must consider the cost of treatment, the level of suffering, and the patient's wishes, among other factors. Simple tables and formulas fail to account for the nuances of

individual values and personal circumstances while overlooking the reality of the risk that individuals may be unwilling to take on. Although the values in these scenarios are subjective and could vary, the fundamental argument remains: expected utility tables fall short of addressing all facets of decision-making.

Section III: Rebuttal

In this section, I will now offer a defense to a potential objection against my claim. One might argue that an infinite expected utility is so much greater than finite expected utilities that it would overshadow the other outcomes, forcing one to choose that option. Let's reconsider the scenario presented by the author, with two choices: either the belief or disbelief in God. Comparing the expected utilities of the two scenarios, believing in God is the rational choice. The expected utility of infinity would be infinitely preferable to a finite expected utility, no matter how high the finite value might be. The disbelief in God is completely overshadowed as it cannot mathematically compete with an outcome that promises a chance at an infinite or unlimited reward.

However, while an expected utility of infinity may seem compelling, I argue that it does not justify choosing an option when the probability of the outcome makes it impractical. Reconsider the example of the God scenario with an adjusted probability of the 1st option.

	God exists (0.00001%)	God doesn't exist (99.99%)	Expected Utility
Believe in God	∞	2	∞
Don't believe in God	1	3	3

The probability that God exists is now 1 in a billion, which is roughly the chance of flipping a coin and getting heads 30 times in a row. Despite this incredibly low probability, the expected utility of this eventuality remains infinite. However, such minimal odds act as a strong deterrent against choosing the first scenario, with the small likelihood of God existing making the choice unrealistic. The probability of God's existence is so low that it would do little to convince some people to go to Church every single Sunday, avoid sinning entirely, and completely change the way they live their lives. Choosing not to believe in God and living freely would be a respected and valid decision, regardless of the higher expected utility of his belief. This demonstrates that one shouldn't always choose the option with the greatest expected utility, as other practical factors can outweigh improbable outcomes.